the party focused on projecting several non-Yadav and non-Jatav leaders from the MBCs: leaders like Ashok Katariya from Bijnor, Rama Shankar Katheria in Agra and the Kurmi leader Anupriya Patel from its alliance partner Apna Dal. In Muzaffarnagar, the party bet on Sanjeev Baliyan. While he gained a reputation as a local Hindutva rabble-rouser, Baliyan also symbolised the BJP's understanding of local caste structures and its on-the-ground social engineering.

The only other party to build such a line-up of second-line local leaders in UP was the SP in Mulayam Singh Yadav's heyday. Yadav, says the journalist Pranshu Mishra, 'allowed local leaders to grow: like Azam Khan, Ramakant Yadav. They did their own thing in their areas but always remained behind Netaji. BSP, on the other hand, didn't create a local leadership. It only relied on its cadre but never allowed locally recognisable leaders to be created. Congress only always had feudal leaders in the last couple of decades and no cadres.'

What Modi and Shah did in UP was a far more fundamental structural change—infusing members of OBC castes in significant proportions at every level that matters: parliamentary and assembly candidates, state-level apex leadership, council of ministers and district- and booth-level leadership. This major shift in the BJP's organisational DNA led to the creation of a new political system. 'BJP's organisational bouquet is such, whether it is the PM, whether the state president, whether organisational general secretaries, whether regional president, whether district presidents and after that our candidates—we have without any discrimination tried to give people what is their right. We went to the people for their support in elections with this leadership, with this confidence and right that the very grand bouquet that BJP has built, they can say that my [people's] face is also in it. In that the biggest face is that of the PM. If today the Backward Classes are with the BJP, it is because of this and they see that if they get due respect, it is so only and only in the BJP,' Maurya explains to me at his home on Lucknow's Kalidas Marg. 'Within BJP, there is a bouquet of various classes and people. When a person looks at it, he feels that he is represented, feels that my person is also there, I also have a space.'[57]